

THE CAGE DOESN'T END

A Plain Language Guide
When You Turn 65 — It Changes Shape



This guide is for everyone.

If you live with a disability — this explains the system you are inside, and what it changes into when you turn sixty-five.

If you are a worker who has never thought of yourself as part of the disability community — this is what happens if your body fails.

If you support an aging or disabled person — this shows you the architecture they are inside.
Every section ends with a green box. The green box gives you words to use.

Alberta Disability System Breakdown — May 2026

A Note Before You Read

Some of what is in this guide is hard to read. It talks about workplace injury. About money lost. About what happens to seniors who do not have enough. It talks about people who never reached the senior system because they did not live long enough to get there.

It does this because the disability and senior systems Albertans live inside today were not designed around any one person's specific case. They were designed around the shape of every recipient — and the shape of every recipient includes the people who fall.

This guide is not written to alarm you. It is written to name plainly what the architecture is, so that when someone tells you *"this is just how it is,"* you have the words to say: **this is something that was built. It can be unbuilt.**

If a page becomes too much, skip it. Come back to it later. Or don't. What matters is that this information exists, and that it is free, and that it can be read aloud.

PAGE 1 — THE CASCADE STARTS ON A TUESDAY



ONE INJURY ON A TUESDAY CAN MOVE A WORKING ALBERTAN INTO THE DISABILITY SYSTEM FOR THE REST OF THEIR LIFE.

You are a worker. You earn a wage. You have paid taxes, CPP, and EI for twenty-five years.

On a Tuesday in November, something happens. A fall. A load shifts. A vehicle hits yours on the way to a job site. Your back, which has been telling you something is wrong for years, finally tells you in a way that ends the work day.

The mechanism does not matter. **What matters is what comes next.**

For the first twelve weeks, you are on WCB — the Workers' Compensation Board of Alberta. WCB pays a wage-replacement benefit while you recover.

Then things start to shift. WCB may decide you can do **some other job**, even if no one is hiring you for it. Your benefit drops.

Eventually WCB ends. You apply for AISH — the Assured Income for the Severely Handicapped. AISH is the program of last resort. By the time you arrive, your savings are gone, the runway is consumed, and the benefit is the floor.

What does "cascade" mean here?

It means a sequence of programs, each one harder than the last to qualify for and each one paying less than the one before. Workers do not arrive at AISH fresh. They arrive after WCB has ended, after Employment Insurance sickness benefits have run out, after savings are depleted, after credit is maxed, after family supports are exhausted.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "If a worker gets hurt, the WCB pays them for a while. After that, WCB can decide they could do a different job — even if nobody will actually hire them. The benefit drops. The worker is then sent to AISH. The cascade is the path from one injury to a lifetime in the disability system."



THE WAGE WCB WILL PAY YOU IS NOT THE WAGE YOU EARNED. AND AT 65, IT DROPS AGAIN.

WCB pays a wage-replacement benefit at **90 percent of net earnings** — your pay after tax, CPP, and EI are removed.

But there is a cap. In 2026, the cap is **\$110,900 per year**. If you earned more than that, WCB treats you as if you earned the cap. The income above the cap is not insured for wage replacement.

The cap was removed in Alberta from September 2018 to December 2020. It was restored on January 1, 2021. Two workers with identical injuries and identical earnings get different benefits, depending on what date they were hurt.

If WCB and your doctor disagree, the dispute goes to appeal. The appeal can take **eighteen months to three years**.

The cliff at 65. If you receive an Economic Loss Payment from WCB, the benefit is recalculated on your sixty-fifth birthday. The new amount is two percent of everything WCB has paid you since the accident.

WCB's own example: a worker receiving \$4,000 per month at age 64 has their benefit reduced to **\$805 per month** on their sixty-fifth birthday. One day. Eighty percent gone.

What is "deeming"?

Deeming is when WCB stops paying you the full benefit because they have decided you could earn money in a different job — even if no employer is actually hiring you for that job. The wage WCB credits you with is theoretical. The lost wage is real. Most workers who are deemed never receive the wage WCB has assigned them.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "WCB does not pay your full wage. There is a cap. There is also a deeming rule that lets WCB cut your benefit based on a job you do not actually have. And on your sixty-fifth birthday, the benefit drops again — by as much as eighty percent — overnight."



TO QUALIFY FOR AISH, YOU MUST FIRST LOSE EVERYTHING.

AISH pays **\$1,940 per month**. To get it, you must prove three things: a permanent disability, low income, and almost no savings.

The savings limit is **\$5,000 for a single person**. Ten thousand dollars for a family with dependents. Almost everything counts: chequing, savings, RRSP, TFSA, GICs, stocks, the cash value of life insurance.

If you have \$23,000 in an RRSP saved over twenty years, you have to collapse it. Collapsing an RRSP triggers withholding tax — up to **30 percent**. The rest is added to your income for the year and taxed again at year-end.

Then you need a doctor. The form requires a physician's signature. As of 2024, **650,000 Albertans had no family physician**. Walk-in clinics generally will not complete the form. The provincial supplement to compensate the doctor is \$150. Most clinics charge \$250 to \$400.

Once your application is in, you wait. Six months, sometimes more than two years. During the wait, you have no AISH income. Many applicants experience eviction, hospitalization, or homelessness during the wait.

What does "asset spend-down" actually mean for a family?

It means you have to liquidate the savings you built before AISH will pay you. The retirement money is gone. The tax has been paid. The vehicle, if it is worth more than the exemption, has been sold. By the time the program approves you, the runway you built across decades of work has been consumed — and the program then pays subsistence.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "AISH pays \$1,940 a month. To qualify, you have to spend down almost all your savings. You also have to find a doctor — in a province where 650,000 people don't have one. Then you wait six months to two years. During the wait, you get nothing."



ON JULY 1, 2026, ABOUT 79,290 ALBERTANS ARE MOVED TO A LOWER-PAYING PROGRAM. NO ONE IS ASKED.

On July 1, 2026, AISH is replaced for most current recipients by a new program called ADAP — the Alberta Disability Assistance Program.

The base benefit drops from **\$1,940 to \$1,740 per month**. A temporary supplement covers the difference until December 31, 2027. After that, ADAP recipients receive \$1,740 with no supplement.

The two-percent annual cost-of-living increase that AISH had — written into law — has been **removed**. Future increases are at the government's discretion, with no statutory floor.

The amount you can earn from work before your benefit is reduced has been cut. Under current AISH it is **\$1,072 per month**. Under ADAP it is \$700. Under post-July-2026 AISH (for the few who remain on it) the exemption is \$350.

You are not asked which program you would prefer. The transition is automatic. To stay on AISH, you must apply with a fresh medical form — in the same province where 650,000 people have no family doctor.

If you cannot get the form in time, you are moved to ADAP by default. The default is the lower-paying program with reduced rights.

What is the Medical Review Panel that replaces the appeal process?

On December 9, 2025, the Alberta Legislature passed Bill 12. Bill 12 abolished the independent Citizens Appeal Panel — a community body whose decisions were binding and could reverse a denial. In its place, Bill 12 created a Medical Review Panel composed of doctors selected by the government. Its decisions are final. There is no independent appeal.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "On July 1, 2026, the disability program changes. The benefit drops by \$200 a month. The cost-of-living increase is removed. The independent appeal panel was abolished in December 2025. About 79,290 Albertans are moved to the lower-paying program automatically — they are not asked."

PAGE 5 — THE COHABITATION RULE



TO RECEIVE AISH, YOU MUST EITHER LIVE ALONE — OR LOSE IT.

If you are on AISH and you live with another adult, that adult's income is counted against your benefit. It does not matter who they are.

A married spouse, a common-law partner, a roommate, an adult child temporarily home, an elderly parent in a basement suite — all are treated the same way under the household-income rule.

Under current AISH, the protected amount of partner income is **\$2,612 per month**. Under ADAP after July 1, 2026, it drops to **\$1,500**. Above the protected amount, your benefit is cut.

The rule means a working spouse cannot work less without losing income the household needs, and cannot work more without losing the benefit. The household is financially trapped at one fixed level.

In a province with no rent cap and average one-bedroom rent of \$1,500 to \$1,900, the recipient is required by the rules to maintain a single-occupant household — at a benefit that does not cover the cost of one.

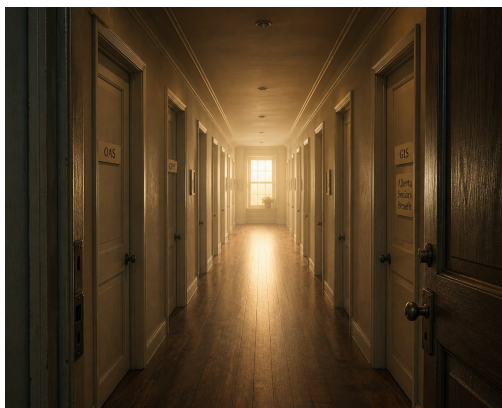
For the 5,426 single mothers on AISH in Alberta, almost all of them women, the rule operates with particular force. The structurally safest financial choice is to stay alone.

Why does the rule say a person should be alone when isolation makes their conditions worse?

Many AISH-qualifying conditions — depression, anxiety, PTSD, brain injury — are made worse by social isolation. The clinical literature on this is unambiguous. A program rule that financially penalizes every shared living arrangement except solitude is, in practice, a rule that worsens the conditions it is supposed to address.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "If a person on AISH lives with another adult, their benefit is reduced by that person's income. It applies to spouses, roommates, anyone. It means people on AISH are financially safest if they live alone — even when their conditions get worse from isolation."



AT 65, THE PROVINCIAL DISABILITY PROGRAM ENDS. NOTHING IS COORDINATED FOR WHAT COMES NEXT.

On your sixty-fifth birthday, several things happen at once.

AISH or ADAP **ends**. The province assumes you are now a senior, not a disability program recipient.

Old Age Security begins, if you have lived in Canada long enough. The 2026 amount for ages 65 to 74 is **\$742.31 per month**.

Canada Pension Plan retirement begins. The maximum new pension in 2026 is \$1,507.65 per month. The **average** new pension is \$925.35 — about three-fifths of the maximum. For a worker whose contributions were interrupted by disability at age 42, the actual amount is around \$300 to \$600.

Guaranteed Income Supplement begins, if your income is low enough. Maximum single GIS is **\$1,109.85 per month**.

None of these transitions is coordinated. There is no single transition office. There is no single application.

Total monthly income at 65 for a worker who came through the cascade: about **\$2,000 to \$2,300**. The poverty line for a single senior in Edmonton in 2026 is about \$25,000 to \$27,000 a year. The senior years begin at the floor.

What about the WCB benefit at 65?

For workers receiving Economic Loss Payments through WCB, the benefit is recalculated at 65 — usually reducing the monthly amount by seventy to ninety percent. A worker can argue they would have kept working past 65 had they not been hurt, but the burden of proof is on the worker. Most arguments are not successful. The cliff arrives.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "At 65, the disability program ends. The senior programs begin — but you have to apply for each one separately. Nothing is coordinated. Most workers arrive at 65 with monthly income near the poverty line."

PAGE 7 — OLD AGE SECURITY



OAS IS A PROMISE PAID OUT OF THIS YEAR'S BUDGET — NOT OUT OF A SAVINGS ACCOUNT WITH YOUR NAME ON IT.

Most Canadians believe Old Age Security is something they paid for during their working years. It is not. OAS is funded from the **general tax revenue of the federal government**, in the year it is paid. There is no OAS payroll deduction. There is no account in your name. Parliament pays OAS the same way it pays for highways, courts, or military procurement.

This matters because what Parliament has chosen to pay, Parliament can choose differently. In 2012, the federal Conservative government raised the eligibility age from 65 to 67. In 2016, the federal Liberal government reversed it back to 65.

The 2026 maximum OAS is **\$742.31 per month** for ages 65 to 74. For ages 75 and over, it is **\$816.54 per month**.

OAS is income-tested at the upper end. Above \$93,454 in net income, fifteen cents of every additional dollar is clawed back. By about \$151,668, the OAS pension is fully recovered.

OAS does not include a survivor benefit. When an OAS recipient dies, the OAS ends. The surviving spouse receives nothing from the deceased spouse's OAS.

Should I defer OAS to age 70 to get a bigger pension?

You can. Each month of deferral past 65 increases the monthly amount by 0.6 percent — up to 36 percent more at age 70. But the deferral only works if you can afford to wait, and only pays off if you live past about age 80. People with shorter life expectancies — including people with disabilities, Indigenous people, and lower-income Canadians — are penalized by the math. A senior in Alberta who defers OAS also loses access to every Alberta provincial seniors program during the deferral period.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "OAS is not a savings account. There is no account in your name. It is paid out of this year's federal budget. The amount and the eligibility age can be — and have been — changed by whichever government is in power."

PAGE 8 — THE CANADA PENSION PLAN



CPP IS NOT YOUR MONEY. IT IS A FORMULA. THE FORMULA IS WHAT IT IS.

Most Canadians believe their CPP contributions are saved up for them — like a bank account that grows over a career and pays out at retirement. They are not.

CPP contributions from every worker are pooled into a single fund. There is no record of "your" contributions and no balance growing in your name. The fund pays benefits to every recipient through a formula — and the formula is what it is.

The 2026 contribution rate is **5.95 percent** of pensionable earnings up to the YMPE — the Year's Maximum Pensionable Earnings — of **\$74,600**. Your employer matches. Self-employed workers pay both halves, totalling 11.9 percent.

Earnings above the cap do not generate CPP entitlement. A worker who earned \$150,000 a year for thirty years paid about half a million dollars in income tax on the income above the cap — none of which produces additional CPP at retirement.

The maximum new CPP retirement pension at 65 in January 2026 is **\$1,507.65 per month**.

The **average** new CPP retirement pension is **\$925.35** — about 60 percent of the maximum.

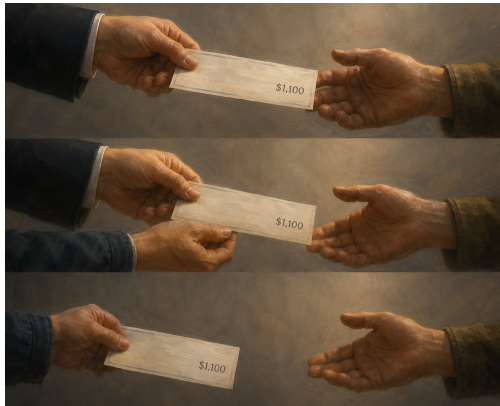
What is the 2019 CPP enhancement?

In 2019, federal legislation began phasing in a higher CPP — raising the income-replacement rate from 25 percent of pre-retirement earnings to 33 percent. The improvement applies only to contributions made after 2019 and is credited proportionally over the contributor's remaining working years. A worker who is 40 today will get a meaningful increase. A worker who is 60 today will get a small one. A worker who is 75 today gets nothing from it.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "CPP is not a savings account. It is an insurance program. Your contributions are pooled with everyone else's. A formula decides what you get back. The formula is capped — most workers receive about 60 percent of the maximum."

PAGE 9 — CPP DISABILITY: THE CONTRIBUTION THAT WAS CAPTURED



16,161 ALBERTANS PAID INTO CPP. WHEN THEY GOT THE BENEFIT, ALBERTA TOOK IT BACK.

CPP Disability is the federal benefit for working-age Canadians whose severe and prolonged disability ends their ability to work. The 2026 maximum is about \$1,756 per month. The average new benefit is \$1,100 to \$1,300.

To qualify, you must have made CPP contributions in **four of the last six years**, and you must show your disability is "severe and prolonged." The first-application denial rate has historically been 50 to 60 percent.

Now the structural part. In Alberta, every dollar of CPP-D is deducted dollar-for-dollar from AISH. A recipient on AISH who qualifies for \$1,100 of CPP-D sees their AISH cut by \$1,100. **The total monthly income does not change.**

As of September 2025, **16,161 Albertans on AISH were receiving CPP-D** — 20.4 percent of the entire AISH caseload. Every one of them paid CPP through their working years. Every one of them gets zero net benefit from those contributions.

The same pattern operates for the federal Canada Disability Benefit. The CDB is a federal program paying up to \$200 per month, designed to lift disabled Canadians above the poverty line. **Alberta is the only province in Canada that claws it back dollar-for-dollar.** The federal payment arrives in the bank; the provincial cheque is reduced by the same amount.

Why is this not reformed?

Because in budget terms, the offset benefits the province at the federal government's expense, with no cost to the recipient relative to no offset. The federal government pays the recipient; the province reduces its cheque by the same amount; the province's net outlay drops by the federal contribution. The campaign has called on the federal government to make federal disability transfers conditional on provinces not clawing them back.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "Some Albertans on AISH paid into CPP for years. When they get the federal disability benefit, Alberta deducts it dollar-for-dollar from their AISH. They get nothing extra from what they paid in. Alberta is the only province in Canada that does this with the federal Canada Disability Benefit."



A LOW-INCOME COUPLE LOSES \$10,602 A YEAR IN GIS — FOR BEING TOGETHER.

The Guaranteed Income Supplement is the federal program designed to lift low-income seniors above the floor that OAS alone would leave them on.

The 2026 maximum GIS for a single senior is **\$1,109.85 per month**.

The 2026 maximum GIS for each member of a senior couple is **\$668.08 per month**.

Two single seniors at low income receive a combined GIS of **\$2,219.70 per month**.

The same two people, married or common-law, at the same income, in the same housing market — combined GIS is **\$1,336.16 per month**.

The difference is **\$883.54 per month**, or **\$10,602 per year**, for being together rather than apart. This is not a calculation. It is the published federal benefit table.

Service Canada has a form for this. It is called **Form ISP-3040 — "Statement: Spouses or Common-law Partners Living Apart for Reasons Beyond their Control."** The existence of the form is the federal government acknowledging, in its own paperwork, that being apart yields more benefits than being together.

What about people who never reach 65?

Single Canadians aged 60 to 64 who are not the spouse of an OAS recipient and have not been widowed are not eligible for any federal senior income support. Their only options are provincial Income Support at much lower rates, or early CPP retirement at a permanently reduced rate. This is the 60-to-64 gap zone. It hits single women hardest.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "The federal Guaranteed Income Supplement pays a low-income couple about \$10,600 a year less than it would pay the same two people if they lived apart. The federal government has a form to let couples claim individual GIS — but only if they live apart for 'reasons beyond their control.'"

PAGE 11 — ALBERTA'S SENIOR PROGRAMS AND THE 2026 CUTS



ON JULY 1, 2026, ABOUT 6,000 TO 8,000 ALBERTA SENIORS LOSE THE PROVINCIAL SUPPLEMENT.

Alberta has a layer of provincial programs that supplement the federal floor. The largest is the **Alberta Seniors Benefit** — a monthly cash payment of up to **\$328 per month for a single senior** and **\$493 per month for a senior couple**.

About 194,000 Albertans currently receive the Alberta Seniors Benefit.

The provincial budget tabled February 26, 2026 announced a **9 percent cut to the income thresholds** for the program, effective July 1, 2026. The maximum benefits stay the same. The income limit at which you become ineligible drops.

Public Interest Alberta estimates that **6,000 to 8,000 Alberta seniors will lose Alberta Seniors Benefit eligibility** on July 1, 2026 because of the threshold cut. The same date is the AISH-to-ADAP transition. Two cuts, same day.

Every Alberta seniors program — Alberta Seniors Benefit, Special Needs Assistance for Seniors, Coverage for Seniors prescription drugs, Dental and Optical Assistance — has the same hidden requirement: **you must be receiving OAS**.

For seniors in continuing care, the province guarantees **\$373 per month** in disposable income after accommodation charges are paid. That is about twelve dollars per day — for everything that is not the room, the meals, and the basic care.

What does \$373 a month cover?

It covers everything the continuing care home does not provide. A long-distance phone call to family. A haircut at the on-site barber. A birthday card for a grandchild. A new pair of slippers when the old ones wear out. Medications not covered by Coverage for Seniors. For the months and years a senior is in continuing care, twelve dollars a day is what they have.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "The Alberta Seniors Benefit pays low-income seniors about \$328 to \$493 a month. Starting July 1, 2026, the income thresholds drop by 9 percent. About 6,000 to 8,000 seniors lose the supplement on that day. The same day is the AISH-to-ADAP transition."



THE SYSTEM REASSESSES YOU CONTINUOUSLY. EACH REASSESSMENT IS A CHANCE TO REDUCE WHAT YOU GET.

There is no single point in Canadian life when a permanent finding of disability or need produces permanent support.

A child born with a disability is reassessed at every transition — into school, between grades, into specialized programs. Family Support for Children with Disabilities funding is reviewed annually.

At **age 18**, FSCD ends. The young adult applies fresh for AISH or PDD. The supports in place since infancy may not carry forward at the same level — or at all.

AISH recipients are reassessed periodically. Each reassessment requires updated medical and financial documentation.

On **July 1, 2026**, AISH-to-ADAP is a fresh adjudication for 79,290 recipients — by a Medical Review Panel that did not exist before.

At **age 65**, AISH ends, OAS begins, CPP-D converts to CPP retirement, GIS is calculated, Alberta Seniors Benefit is calculated, Coverage for Seniors begins. Each is a separate application.

At **death**, the surviving spouse's GIS, Alberta Seniors Benefit, and CPP are recalculated against single-rate income tests. Income drops, often by more than half.

Why is the system designed this way?

The system was not designed to ensure stable support. It was designed to make periodic determinations of eligibility against criteria that may change between determinations. Each reassessment requires the recipient to demonstrate continued eligibility. Each reassessment is permitted to reduce benefits if the criteria, the documentation, the political environment, or the budget context permits.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "There is no point in Canadian life where a permanent disability or need produces permanent support. Every transition is a fresh assessment. Every assessment can reduce what you get. The system is designed for continuous reassessment, not for stable support."



YOU PAID FOR DECADES. THE FORMULA DECIDES WHAT YOU GET. THE TWO ARE NOT THE SAME THING.

The intuitive belief is that the contributions you made — CPP, EI, federal income tax, provincial income tax, GST, fuel tax, property tax — give you a meaningful claim on what you receive back from the public system.

The structural reality is that contributions and benefits are not connected the way the belief assumes.

CPP is not a savings account. Contributions are pooled. There is no individual account. The formula decides.

The formula is capped. Earnings above \$85,000 a year do not generate CPP entitlement.

Provincial clawbacks erase the federal benefit. AISH deducts CPP-D dollar-for-dollar. Alberta deducts the federal Canada Disability Benefit dollar-for-dollar.

GIS clawback halves the saver's advantage. Each dollar of CPP retirement, workplace pension, or investment income reduces GIS by about fifty cents.

The programs were designed for a poverty floor — not for income adequacy. CPP was supposed to replace 25 percent of pre-retirement earnings (now phasing toward 33 percent). Workplace pensions and personal savings were supposed to do the rest. Workplace pensions have eroded. Personal savings have not made up the gap.

What does this mean in plain words?

It means the senior who tried to do everything right finishes within hailing distance of the senior who did not. The system is a set of distinct programs operating with distinct rules and distinct capture mechanisms. The contributor experiences it as one thing. It operates as several things.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "What you paid in does not determine what you get back. A formula does. The formula is capped. Provincial clawbacks erase the federal benefit. The programs were designed as a poverty floor, not as full retirement income."



HEARING AIDS. HOME CARE. DENTAL CROWNS. MENTAL HEALTH COUNSELLING. THE PUBLIC SYSTEM DOES NOT COVER THEM.

About 47 percent of Canadians 65 and over have measurable hearing loss. A pair of mid-tier hearing aids in Canada costs **\$2,000 to \$7,000**. Replacement is typically needed every five to seven years. Alberta covers part of the cost — up to \$500 per year, with a 25 percent copay.

Home care is provided by Alberta Health Services based on assessed need. Private home care fills the gap. Private home care in Alberta costs **\$25 to \$80 per hour**. For a senior needing daily assistance, that runs **\$4,000 to \$8,000 per month** — well above any senior's income from OAS, GIS, and the Alberta Seniors Benefit combined.

Major dental work — crowns, bridges, root canals, implants — is covered partially or not at all. Costs run to thousands or tens of thousands of dollars.

Mental health is covered if the practitioner is a physician. Psychologists, social workers, counsellors, and psychotherapists are not covered under provincial insurance. Wait times for publicly funded mental health are documented in months and years.

For transportation, vision aids beyond basic glasses, specialized mobility equipment, and most home accessibility modifications, the same pattern holds. The senior whose needs match the program inventory is supported. The senior whose needs fall in a gap pays out of pocket — or does without, out of about **\$20,000 to \$26,000 per year** for a single senior at the floor.

What about housing?

The federal-and-provincial income support architecture does not include direct housing-cost protection. In Alberta, average market rent for a one-bedroom apartment exceeds the AISH or ADAP benefit. For seniors, OAS plus GIS does not cover average rent in most Alberta cities. Alberta has no rent cap. Community housing wait times can exceed five years.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "The public system covers a poverty floor of income. It does not cover hearing aids, full home care, full dental work, most mental health counselling, comprehensive transportation, or housing. The recipient pays out of pocket — or does without."



THE AVERAGE FIRST NATIONS ALBERTAN DOES NOT LIVE TO REACH OAS.

The senior income system in Canada is built around the assumption that you will reach age 65 and live for some years past it. Average Canadian life expectancy at birth is about 81.5 years.

For First Nations Albertans, the average is different. In 2023, the average life expectancy at birth for a First Nations person in Alberta was **62.81 years**. For non-First Nations Albertans, it was **81.88 years**.

The gap is **19.07 years**.

It means that, on average, a First Nations Albertan dies **about two years before becoming eligible for OAS**. The federal OAS, the federal GIS, the Alberta Seniors Benefit, Coverage for Seniors, and the long-term care system are an architecture that does not, on average, arrive in time.

The CPP contributions made through working years produce no senior-stage benefit because there is no senior stage. The federal income tax paid produced general government revenue but no recoverable retirement income.

For First Nations Albertans who do reach 65, the architecture engages with additional friction. Long-term care facilities on reserve are limited; most Indigenous seniors who need LTC are placed off-reserve, often far from family, language, ceremony, and community.

The 19.07-year gap is not nature. It is the cumulative outcome of policy choices documented for centuries.

What does the campaign's Indigenous Disability in Alberta report cover?

The Indigenous Disability in Alberta report, published April 2026, walks fourteen evidentiary sections — residential schools and Indian Hospitals; the mortality gap; jurisdictional fracture; housing crisis; contaminated land; healthcare racism; Jordan's Principle; child welfare; the justice system; MMIWG2S+; consultation failures; the Alberta Sovereignty Act and Treaty; and TRC Calls 18 to 24. It is free at the campaign website. It can be read aloud.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "The senior income system in Canada starts at age 65. The average First Nations Albertan dies about two years before reaching it. The contributions they made through their working years produce no senior-stage benefit because there is no senior stage. The 19-year mortality gap is what that looks like in numbers."



THE BENEFIT-CALCULATION HISTORY IS SHORTER THAN THE RELATIONSHIP HISTORY.

Same-sex sexual activity between consenting adults was decriminalized in Canada on June 27, 1969. A senior who is 75 today was born in 1951. They lived their entire childhood, adolescence, and most of their early career during the criminalization period.

Federal recognition of same-sex common-law partnerships came in **2000**. Same-sex marriage was legalized federally in **2005**. Workplace discrimination based on sexual orientation was lawful in most Canadian jurisdictions until human-rights legislation incrementally addressed it through the 1980s and 2000s. Workplace discrimination based on gender identity was not addressed federally until 2017.

For a 2SLGBTQ+ senior today, the federal benefit-calculation history may be much shorter than their actual relationship history. CPP retirement is calculated against contribution histories that were suppressed by lawful workplace discrimination during the working years.

The architecture also does not recognize **family of choice** — the chosen-family relationships that have, since the criminalization period, served as the functional family unit for many 2SLGBTQ+ Canadians. A chosen-family partner has no rights to survivor benefits, no rights to spousal CPP credit splitting, and no formal status as a substitute decision-maker.

The most consistent concern documented in advocacy literature is fear of "going back into the closet" upon entering long-term care. A 2024 U.S. study found **71 percent** of LGBTQ+ adults aged 50 and over were concerned about access to future caregiving.

What about trans seniors specifically?

For trans seniors, federal records may show different names or gender markers across the contribution history, producing administrative friction during OAS, GIS, and CPP applications. Long-term care facilities are not, with limited exceptions, designed around trans inclusion. Body care during bathing, the use of correct names and pronouns, gender-affirming hormone therapy, and surgical history are categories most Canadian LTC facilities do not have established policies or trained staff for.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "Many 2SLGBTQ+ seniors today were adults during decades when their relationships were not legally recognized and when workplace discrimination against them was lawful. The benefit calculations the federal government uses are based on shorter contribution histories than they would have had without that discrimination. Family of choice is not recognized in the system. Long-term care is the most documented fear."

PAGE 17 — IMMIGRANT SENIORS UNDER 20-YEAR SPONSORSHIP



IF YOU ARRIVED AFTER 2014 ON PARENT-AND-GRANDPARENT SPONSORSHIP, YOU WAIT 20 YEARS FOR GIS.

Old Age Security pays the maximum pension to applicants who have lived in Canada for **40 years or more after age 18**. With less than 40, you receive a partial pension calculated on a fraction.

An immigrant who arrived at age 35 has 30 years of residency at age 65 — qualifying for 75 percent of the maximum, about **\$557 per month**.

An immigrant who arrived at age 50 has 15 years of residency at age 65 — qualifying for about **\$278 per month**.

An immigrant who arrived at age 60 has 5 years of residency at age 65, falling below the 10-year minimum entirely.

On **October 1, 2025**, the federal government brought into force a 2014 amendment that extends the GIS, Allowance, and Allowance for the Survivor exclusion period for sponsored immigrants from 10 years to **20 years** under parent-and-grandparent sponsorship.

The first cohort of sponsored seniors under the 20-year framework arrived in Canada in 2016. They became eligible for partial OAS in 2026. Their eligibility for GIS — the supplement that lifts the partial OAS to a survivable income — is now deferred to **2036**.

For 20 years, the sponsored senior is, in operational reality, dependent on the sponsor for income. Across 20 years, the sponsor's own circumstances — job loss, illness, divorce, death — may change.

What about working-years discrimination?

For Canadian-born racialized seniors and for immigrants who have been in Canada most of their working life, lifetime earnings have been documented as lower because of workplace discrimination. The 2025 National Advisory Council on Poverty report identifies recent immigrants as having a poverty rate of 15.3 percent in 2023, compared with 11.0 percent in the broader population.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "If a senior immigrated to Canada after 2014 under parent-and-grandparent sponsorship, they now wait 20 years — not 10 — before they can receive the federal supplement that lifts low-income seniors above the basic OAS. For two decades, they depend on their sponsor for income."



THE ARCHITECTURE RUNS ON \$97 TO \$130 BILLION A YEAR OF UNPAID LABOUR. THE LABOUR IS DONE BY WOMEN.

About **7.8 million Canadians** act as caregivers for family members with chronic conditions, disabilities, or aging-related needs.

The economic value of that unpaid labour is estimated at **\$97 billion to \$130 billion per year** — comparable to total provincial healthcare spending across the country.

The labour is overwhelmingly performed by women — daughters, daughters-in-law, wives, sisters. The architecture relies on it. It does not pay for it.

The federal Canada Caregiver Credit and the Alberta Caregiver Credit offset a small portion of the cost. Maximum value of the Alberta credits is about **\$1,054 per year**. The 2027 consolidation will leave approximately **9,000 Albertans** losing access.

Three configurations are particularly invisible: **the disabled adult caring for an aging parent** (the cohabitation rule treats the parent's contribution as household income, with no credit for the care); **the parent-caregiver of a disabled adult who enters long-term care themselves** (lifelong primary support is lost; formal supports do not adequately replace it); and **the senior couple where one partner becomes caregiver to the other** (caregiver health deteriorates — depression, cardiovascular disease, premature mortality are consistently documented).

Why is the unpaid labour treated as the architecture's hidden foundation?

Because the federal and provincial systems would not function at the public expenditure levels they currently do without the unpaid caregiving labour. Long-term care covers seniors at one threshold of need; family caregivers fill the substantial gap below that threshold. Home care is allocated at a level that requires family or paid private supplementation. The cost difference is borne by the caregiver — in employment lost, in retirement savings forgone, in mental and physical health.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "About 7.8 million Canadians do unpaid caregiving — worth \$97 to \$130 billion a year, roughly what the provinces spend on healthcare. The federal and provincial systems would not work without it. Most of the labour is done by women. The Alberta caregiver tax credit is about \$1,054 a year — nowhere near the value of what is provided."



EVERY NUMBER IN THIS GUIDE IS A COUNT OF PEOPLE.

This guide has used numbers throughout. The numbers are accurate. The numbers are also, each one of them, a count of people.

79,290 — the count of Albertans on AISH facing the AISH-to-ADAP transition on July 1, 2026. Each one was an applicant once. Each one liquidated retirement savings to clear the asset cap. Each one waited the wait. Each one will be moved to a lower-paying program with reduced rights.

16,161 — the count of Albertans on AISH receiving the federal CPP Disability benefit, whose contribution is captured dollar-for-dollar by the provincial offset. Every one paid CPP through their working years. Every one gets zero net benefit.

19.07 years — the gap between average First Nations and non-First Nations life expectancy at birth in Alberta, 2023.

6,000 to 8,000 — Alberta seniors estimated to lose Alberta Seniors Benefit eligibility on July 1, 2026 when the threshold cut takes effect.

5,426 — single parents on AISH in Alberta, almost entirely women, navigating the cohabitation rule with children to raise.

The cohort that has not survived to be in any database — the senior who died before the dental care that would have prevented the systemic infection, the disabled adult who lost their primary caregiver, the Indigenous person who did not reach 65 — is also part of what has been witnessed.

Who has been doing the work that produced this documentation?

This guide compiles work done across decades by a much broader community. Inclusion Alberta, Inclusion Canada, the Council of Canadians with Disabilities, the Canadian Centre for Policy Alternatives, Egale Canada, Public Interest Alberta, the People's Alliance for Disabled Albertans, the Canadian Centre for Caregiving Excellence, the National Institute on Ageing, AUPE, and Indigenous-led organizations whose work spans centuries.

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "Every number in this guide is a count of people. 79,290 Albertans. 16,161 Albertans. 19.07 years. 6,000 to 8,000 seniors. 5,426 single parents. Each figure is the total of individuals living the reality the guide describes."



YOU ARE NOT INVISIBLE. THE COVENANT EXTENDS TO YOU.

This guide closes the way the Indigenous Disability in Alberta report closed — with a covenant. The covenant is not a policy proposal. It is a recognition.

To the worker whose body has failed — the cascade in this guide is your daily life, or it will be. You are not the failure. The architecture's structural pattern is the failure. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

To the senior who has reached 65 — the published amounts are what you receive. The result was determined by the formula. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

To the Indigenous Albertan — the 19-year mortality gap is not nature. The senior architecture, on average, does not arrive in time. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

To the 2SLGBTQ+ senior — the benefit-calculation history is shorter than your relationship history. The family of choice that has held you for decades is not in the calculation. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

To the immigrant senior — the 20-year sponsorship period is the architecture's structural extension of your dependency. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

To the family caregiver — the architecture relies on your unpaid labour and does not pay you. *You are not invisible. We see you.*

Where to find more

Website: albertadisabilitysystembreakdown.netlify.app

Community group: The Alberta Disability System Breakdown on Facebook (free to join, free to read without joining)

Email: albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com

Email for: the full 117-page *Cage Doesn't End* document, the 195-page *Indigenous Disability in Alberta* report, the 352-page *Building Up* blueprint, the AISH Plain Language Guide, and any other campaign material. **Free. Free to share. Free to print. Free to post.**

■ HOW TO EXPLAIN THIS

Try saying this: "Thousands of people are living what this guide describes. There are reports, there are groups, there are templates, there is a community. Everything is free. Everything can be shared. The cage does not end. It changes shape. We see you. You are not invisible."